

Alcatraz Landing

Audio Stop Graphic Updates
May 07, 2014

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12"

GOLDEN GATE NATIONAL RECREATION AREA

Alcatraz Island is part of the Golden Gate National Recreation Area, an urban park that includes 75,398 acres of land and water extending north of the Golden Gate Bridge in Marin County and south to San Mateo County. These lands represent one of the nation’s largest coastal preserves and attract 16 million visitors each year, making GGNRA one of the National Park Service’s most highly visited units. Golden Gate National Recreation Area, a unit of the National Park Service, was established by Congress in 1972 as part of a trend to make national park resources more accessible to urban populations and bring “parks to the people”.

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Golden Gate National
Recreation Area



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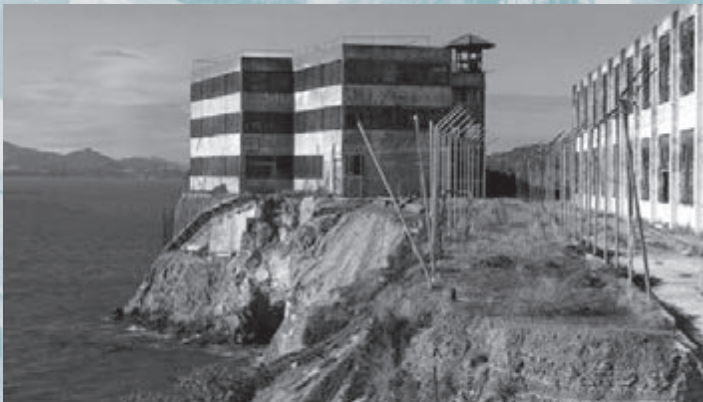
INDUSTRIAL BUILDINGS

Work was a privilege on Alcatraz, and most inmates labored five days a week at menial jobs such as making military uniforms and refinishing furniture. Convicts worked in two large factory buildings separated from the rest of the island by double fences topped with barbed wire. The three-story building at the tip of the island was called Model Shop because it was designed to serve as a “model” of rehabilitation for prisoners. Built by the army in 1922, it contained carpentry, plumbing, and blacksmith shops. The long two-story building, known as New Industries, was constructed by the Bureau of Prisons in 1940 and served as a laundry, dry cleaning plant, and tailor shops.



(to be written in braille)
Industrial Buildings

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Fences, barbed wire, and a guard tower prevented escape from the industrial areas.



Many Alcatraz inmates worked in tailor shops, making gloves and military uniform items.



Interior of one of the Alcatraz industrial buildings.



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POST EXCHANGE & OFFICERS' CLUB

The Alcatraz Post Exchange (PX), or "Soldiers Clubhouse," built in 1910, was the local general store, a place for soldiers and their families to buy food and personal goods. When Alcatraz became a federal prison in 1934, the PX was converted into a recreation hall and correctional officers' club, complete with a dance floor, movie theater, gymnasium, two-lane bowling alley, and soda fountain. The building was one of several destroyed by fire in June 1970.

(to be written in braille)
Post Exchange & Officers' Club



Banquet in the officers' club, 1948.



The basement of the officers' club held a bowling alley used by the island families.



Alcatraz teenagers at an island Christmas party.



Post Exchange token issued during the military era. Coins like this served as currency—but only at Alcatraz.

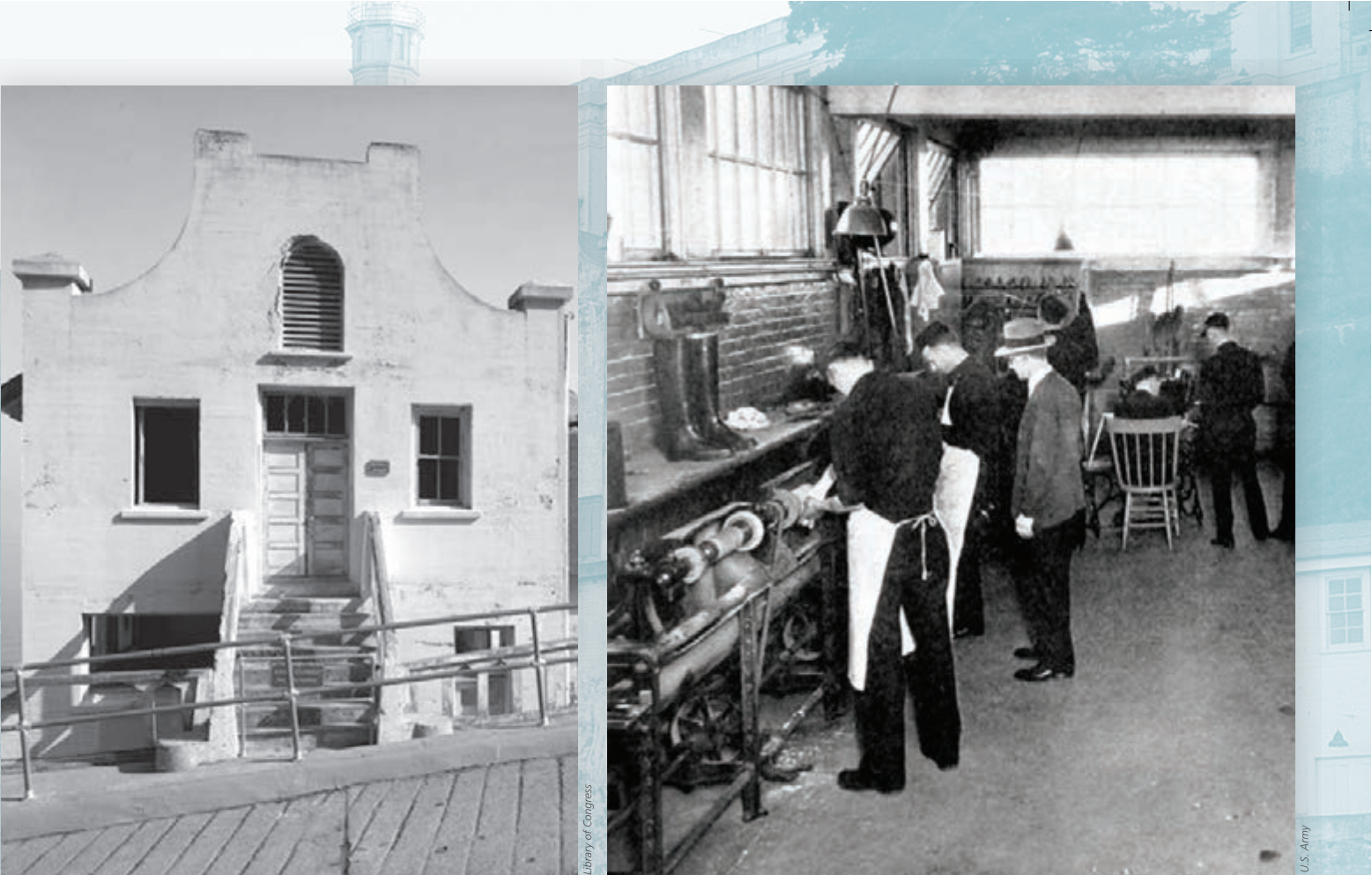
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MILITARY SCHOOLHOUSE

The small building on top of the guardhouse and sally port was built by the Army in 1917. Designed in the Mission Revival style, the schoolhouse originally held a shoe repair shop and hat factory. Later, it served as a classroom where army prisoners received grade school education. In 1934, after the military left and federal prison employees arrived, the building was remodeled into housing for bachelor guards.

(to be written in braille)
Military School House



The Alcatraz military schoolhouse was one of several 'Mission Revival' buildings on the island.

Convicts working in the shoe repair shop on the lower floor, circa 1925.



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GUARDHOUSE & SALLYPORT COMPLEX

Built in 1857, the guardhouse is the oldest building on the island. The first line of defense against enemy landing parties, it could only be entered by crossing a drawbridge over a 15-foot deep dry moat. Two gun ports for 24-pound howitzers flanked the entrance, and firing positions for riflemen capped the roof. Alcatraz's defenses were never tested in battle. Instead, the Guardhouse's basement served as a prison for troublesome army soldiers. Later uses included a military prison, library, theater, and schoolhouse.

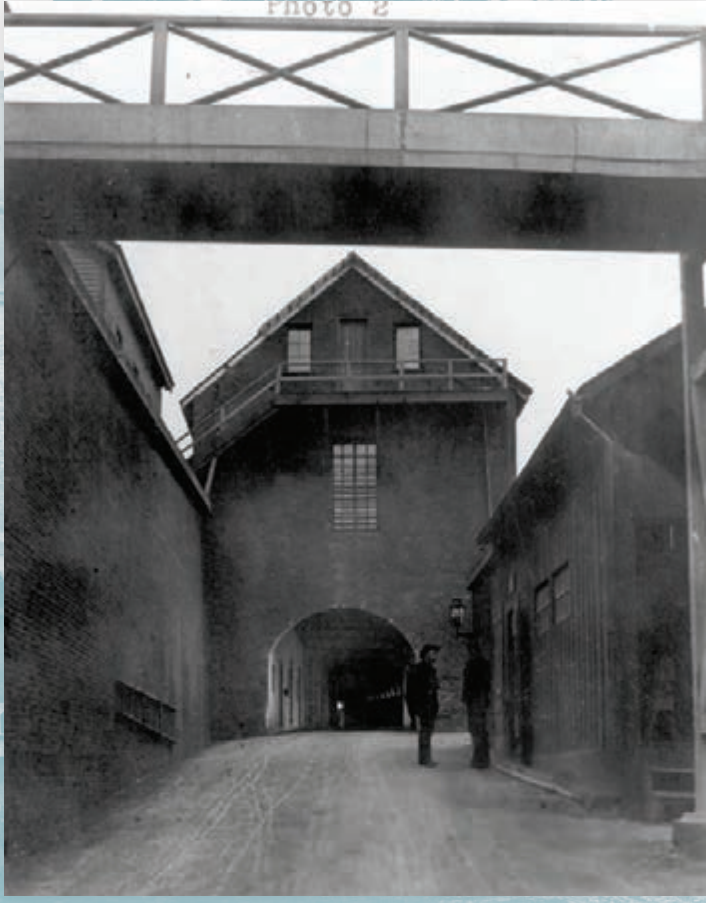
(to be written in braille)
Guardhouse & Sallyport
Complex



The sallyport complex in 1902, when it served as a military prison for U.S. Army convicts.



24-pounder flank defense howitzers like this one guarded the sally port during the Civil War



Entrance to the sally port, 1902. The peaked-roof building housed a library and chapel for military prisoners.



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THE DOCK

The original dock was completed in 1854, and has been modified and enlarged several times since then. The large four-story building immediately behind the dock was once a military barracks. Its ground floor was built between 1865 and 1867. Designed to house soldiers and cannon to defend the dock, its 10-foot-thick brick walls made it virtually bomb-proof. Along today's dock, a row of brick gun casemates can still be seen. The restored guard tower is a remnant of the federal penitentiary era. During those years, six towers around Alcatraz were manned by armed guards, whose clear view made escape by prisoners extremely difficult.

(to be written in braille)
The Dock



Last penitentiary convicts being taken off Alcatraz, March 21, 1963.



An army steamer at the island dock, circa 1902. Note the square cannon ports.



Military personnel and convict workers waiting to board the island launch, circa 1920.



Dock Tower was originally built in 1934. It was the only guard tower manned 24 hours a day.



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BARRACKS/APARTMENTS

In 1905, the army used inmate labor to add three concrete stories on top of the original dock-level brick barracks built in the 1860s. The finished structure, known as Building 64, served as quarters for solders assigned to prison guard duty. In preparation for civilian inmates, the Bureau of Prisons remodeled the barracks building into apartments for correctional officers and their families. The apartment house included a small market and a tiny post office. During the federal penitentiary era, this end of the island was fenced off for the security of the families.

(to be written in braille)
Barracks/Apartments



Island residents named the narrow alley behind the apartment house "Chinatown".



A general store, complete with soda fountain, was located on the first floor of the apartment house.



As many as 75 children lived on Alcatraz at any one time, ranging from toddlers to teenagers. Children went to school in San Francisco.



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STAFF HOUSING AREA

Most of the penitentiary staff, along with their wives and children, lived on Alcatraz. Living quarters included an aging army barracks overlooking the dock, small cottages, and modern apartment houses built in 1940 with spectacular views of the Golden Gate. At the very tip of the island was a duplex occupied by two of the most important people on the island: the associate warden and the captain of the correctional staff. During the 1950s, an average of 75 families lived on the island at any one time. Dozens of children grew up on Alcatraz, and were ferried each day to school in San Francisco. Wives and off-duty guards took the shuttle boat to the city for shopping trips and social events.

(to be written in braille)
Staff Housing Area



Children of U.S. Army officers, circa 1925.



Families with children lived in a fenced-off area at the southern end of Alcatraz.



The vast concrete parade ground served as a playground for Alcatraz children.



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WARDEN'S HOUSE AND LIGHTHOUSE

The warden's house commanded the summit of the island. An impressive Mission Revival-style home, it had seventeen large rooms with sweeping views of the Golden Gate and San Francisco. Built in 1921, it was originally the residence of the military prison commandant. After the island became a federal penitentiary in 1934, it became home to Alcatraz's four wardens.

The lighthouse was originally built in 1854 to guide gold rush shipping into San Francisco Bay. The present concrete tower was erected in 1909. Lighthouse keepers and their families once lived in homes at the tower's base.

(to be written in braille)
Warden's House
and Lighthouse



The second Alcatraz lighthouse and warden's house, 1954.



Warden Edwin Swope and wife Edna at home for Christmas, circa 1950.



The warden's house was the largest residence on the island. Circa 1930.



The original Alcatraz lighthouse. Note the cannonballs. 1890.



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MAIN PRISON BUILDING

In 1907, the War Department drew up plans for a new prison building that could house up to 600 army prisoners. When finished in 1912, the cellhouse was reportedly the largest steel-reinforced concrete building in the world. Unskilled army inmates largely provided the labor. When Alcatraz was chosen as as a federal maximum-security penitentiary in 1934, the aging cellhouse was renovated by the Bureau of Prisons. Tool-proof bars replaced the flat, mild-steel cell fronts of the military prison, and gun galleries were built at either end of the cell room. Also, the number of cells was reduced from 600 to 336.



(to be written in braille)
Main Prison Building

11



The penitentiary cellblocks contained 336 one man cells.



Inmates and correctional officers bundled up against the cold in the recreation yard.



Convicts were allowed yard privileges on weekends.



Alcatraz correctional officers, 1934. Warden James Johnston at center.



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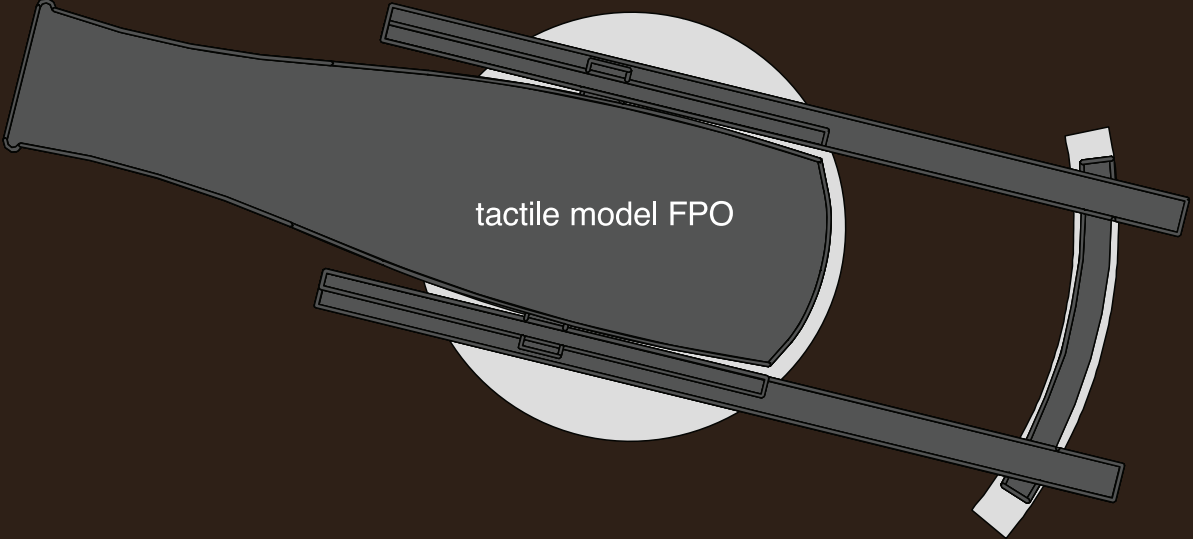
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THE 10-INCH RODMAN

The cannon in front of you is a replica 10-inch Rodman cannon, a typical Alcatraz artillery piece of the 1860s. An actual Rodman gun and carriage was aimed, loaded and fired by a crew of eight to ten soldiers. The large wheels at the rear allowed the crew to rotate the gun right or left on circular iron rails. At the moment of firing, the gun recoiled backwards and up the inclined iron side rails. Friction and gravity made it stop. Weight of gun and carriage: 20,500 lbs. (9298 kilograms) Weight of solid cannonball: 128 lbs. (58 kilograms) Range with 15 lbs. powder: 2.75 miles (4.4 kilometers)

(to be written in braille)
The 10-inch Rodman

14



tactile model FPO

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12"

ALCATRAZ FIRE POWER

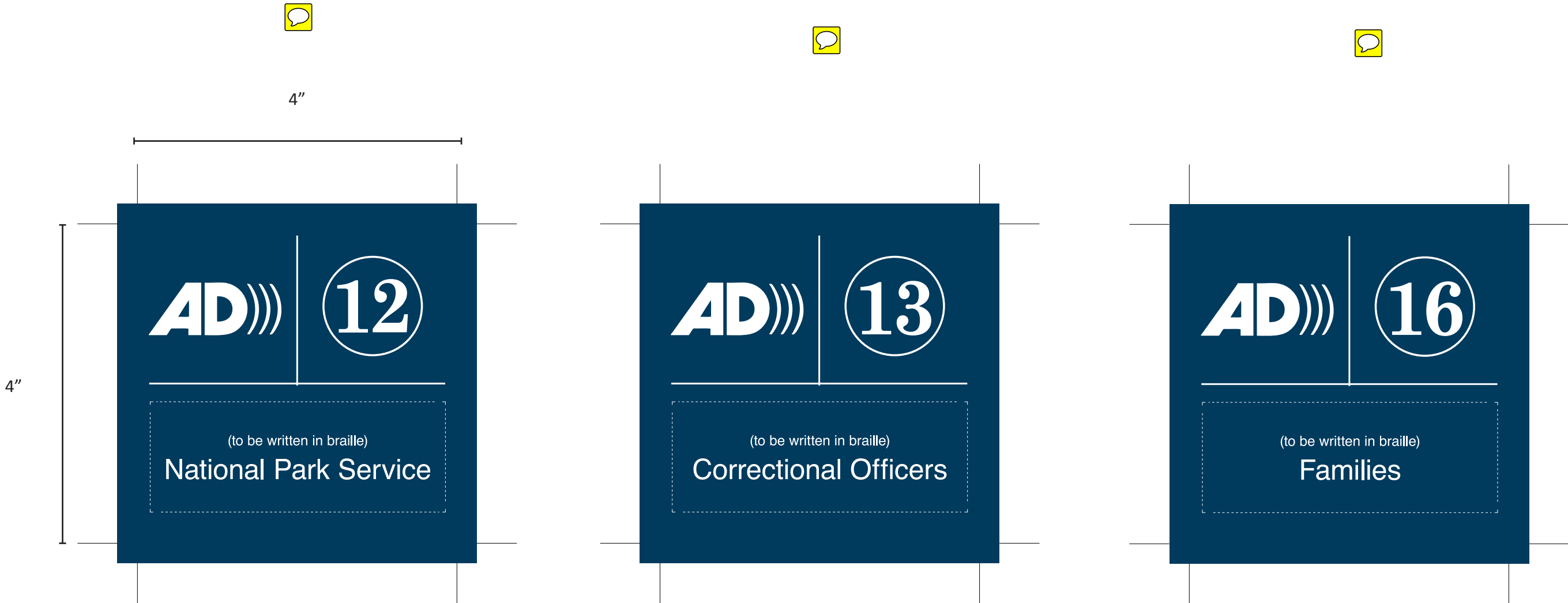
Alcatraz began as a U.S. Army fort, designed to defend San Francisco Bay against enemy attack. At the height of the Civil War, the fortified island held over 100 heavy cannon. The largest of these were the sleek "Rodman" guns on iron carriages. The Rodmans' distinctive soda bottle shape reflected the pressures that built up inside the barrel during firing. Nicknamed after their inventor, Thomas Jackson Rodman, the guns' design and careful manufacture made them very safe weapons to fire, an important feature at a time when many cannon blew up without warning. Rodmans ranged in size from 8-inch caliber guns up through 15-inch caliber models that weighed nearly 50,000 pounds.

(to be written in braille)
Alcatraz Fire Power

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The largest cannon on Alcatraz were 15-inch caliber like the one above. They could fire a 440-lb. cannonball nearly three miles. *Courtesy: Bancroft Library*

Audio Stop 12, 13, 16



Audio Stop 17, 18, 19



Audio Stop 20, 21

